

The Effect of Societal Beauty Standards on Gen-Z Mental Health

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Introduction

There is growing concern that the beauty standards promoted by influencers on social media platforms are contributing to decreased self-esteem and mental health challenges among Gen Z users. While influencers promote idealized versions of beauty, many young viewers may internalize these unrealistic standards, leading to harmful comparisons, body dissatisfaction, and anxiety. We are trying to figure out if the correlation between social media usage and more specifically the influencers watched and if they lead to self-esteem or other mental health problems for the viewers.

Gen-Z, growing up with much more access to digital content than any other generation prior, are especially vulnerable to these effects due to the amount of time they spend on social media and their reliance on it for social connections.

Our research aims to explore the connection between time spent on social media and the negative effects on mental health. Given that we currently live in an era with an abundance of digital platforms and online connections, we believed that exploring social media platforms as a medium would be both relevant and crucial to understand. Social media platforms such as TikTok and Instagram have become powerful tools for expression, as well as a means to disseminate information and establish social expectations. We are more particularly interested in whether constant exposure to societal beauty has an impact on low self-esteem and other mental health issues common in Gen-Z viewers.

Our central research question is *How do societal beauty standards portrayed on social media affect Gen-Z's mental health?* We hope to find evidence that shows a correlation between social media usage and negative mental health problems that develop with Gen-Z users. This

evidence would help us answer our hypothesis which is that *societal beauty standards on social media negatively affect Gen-Z's mental health*.

Literature Review

Generation Z is the first to experience growing up with social media platforms. Experts have determined that the generation is highly active on the majority of social media platforms, and many spend around 2 - 10 hours daily on the apps (The Effects of Social Media on Gen Zs' Mental Health). Generation Z's social media presence greatly increased during the COVID-19 lockdowns in 2020 (The Effects of Social Media on Gen Zs' Mental Health). As the lockdowns took effect, researchers began looking into how their social media usage affected their overall well-being, collecting data leading to the result that an estimated 91% of Generation Z have reported symptoms of physical and emotional stress connected to anxiety (The Effects of Social Media on Gen Zs' Mental Health). As social media usage rose, so did cyberbullying, constant comparison, poorer academic performance, sleeping issues, and disconnection from interpersonal relationships (The Effects of Social Media on Gen Zs' Mental Health). In certain studies, researchers have cultivated data and applied their results to the Social Comparison Theory and discovered that when Generation Z is constantly connected to social media influencers, they tend to heavily compare themselves, often unfavorably (The Influence of Social Media on Perception of Body Image and Beauty Standards on Young People). According to The Impacts of Social Media Influencer Marketing on Body Dysmorphic Disorder Among the Generation Z study, researchers have found possible connections between influencer marketing and body dysmorphic disorder among Generation Z. Influencers marketing products to provide consumers with ways to look like them has proven highly effective for sales however in doing so carries negative repercussions like reinforcing unattainable beauty standards that are not healthy for all people

(The Influence of Tiktok (TT) Advertisement Messages on Health and Beauty Products towards Immoral Behaviour of Gen-Z). This supports the idea that social media can push individuals toward engaging in beauty trends or tips that can prove to be dangerous to achieve societal standards of beauty (Social Media and Its Effects on Beauty).

Research has already proved negative repercussions from social media, like increased social media usage, stress, and unhealthy comparisons. But our project seeks to address exactly how Generation Z is feeling because of the negative repercussions, to discover the toll social media has on their mental health.

Methodology Design

A qualitative research approach was taken for this study. By performing one-on-one interviews, we were able to collect observational data about the effect of beauty standard portrayals on social media has on the mental health of young adults. We chose 4 individuals who fit the criteria for our study (those who were born in Generation Z) and conducted in-depth interviews in-person or on a call, depending on the participants' availability. With participant consent, we took extensive notes on the responses to the prepared questions during the interviews and also asked detailed follow-up questions throughout. We then reviewed and summarized our findings to formulate a conclusion. We believed that performing interviews would allow us to obtain more complex, representative, and personal responses for our research question. Since mental health is a sensitive topic and beauty standards is a complicated concept, interviews allowed us to build rapport with participants and get more honest, extensive answers. By using an interview method, we were able to explore our complex research question thoroughly.

The independent variable of our study is the societal beauty standards portrayed on social media platforms. The operational definition of the independent variable is the content on social media which defines and promotes certain ideals regarding our appearance and behavior. This was measured through prepared interview questions that explored factors such as media consumption habits, favorite celebrities or influencers, and perceived beauty ideals. In turn, the dependent variable is mental health in response to the beauty standards cultivated on social media. This is defined as emotional well-being, which includes self-esteem, anxiety, depression, and the opinion of their own body. Since mental health is difficult to measure numerically, we measured it through the detailed, self-described responses that participants gave during the interviews. To ensure that there were no extraneous variables involved in the study, our controlled variables were age and the questions asked to the participants. Age was defined as college students in the Gen-Z age range (ages 18-22) and the list and order of questions was prepared prior to conducting the interviews.

Before asking individuals to participate in the interviews, we made sure to clearly explain the purpose of the interview and how the information they provided would be used. Additionally, we guaranteed privacy so that participants would feel comfortable providing honest answers without feeling pressured to give biased answers. Lastly, we ensured that sensitive questions were asked at the end of the interview, and interviewees were informed that they were not obligated to answer if they were not comfortable doing so.

Data Analysis

After conducting in-depth interviews with four Gen Z individuals, we used qualitative thematic analysis to identify common themes and emotional responses related to social media beauty standards and their effects on mental health. Four main themes emerged from the

participants' answers: 1) changing norms, 2) standards and achievability, 3) comparisons to others, and 4) fear of judgement.

Theme 1: Changing Norms

While all participants acknowledged the prevalence of traditional beauty norms on social media, such as fragile feminine body types or lean, muscular male physiques, several reported a noticeable shift in recent years toward more inclusive and diverse representations. Participants observed a growing presence of body-positive content and influencers who promote healthier, more attainable standards regarding beauty and appearances. This trend suggests increasing public awareness of the bias and narrowness of conventional beauty ideals. As a result, users start to diversify the types of beauty they present online, allowing for broader definitions beyond thinness or perfection.

“In the past, the standards were more stereotypical. Algorithms funnel what we see. But there is some shift in standards that are pushing back on the norm and creating change.”
(Alex, Q1)

“It depends on what type of social media you see... mine is more about healthy ways to improve life, not unhealthy habits, like on skinny tok.” (Betty, Q4)

Theme 2: Standards and Achievability

Participants widely agreed that the beauty standards promoted on social media are often unrealistic and difficult to achieve. These standards, such as flawless skin, or perfectly styled appearance, were described as requiring significant time, money, and effort. Moreover, participants stated that the lives and images that influencers share online are heavily curated and edited, which creates misleading expectations for viewers about what is “normal.” Adam pointed

out that many fitness influencers have been training for years or may rely on performance-enhancing drugs, making their physique unattainable for normal people.

“We shouldn’t compare our bodies with those gym influencers’ because they’ve been working out for a longer time, and some use PED’s.” (Adam, Q3)

Similarly, Larry emphasized the level of preparation behind polished appearance and stated that such perfection is impossible to maintain all the time, given real-world responsibilities and lifestyles.

“Those preparations need time, money, and energy. It’s so difficult for most of us because we need to study, we need to work. We have things to do.” (Larry, Q3)

However, participants also admitted that not all beauty content is harmful. Betty noted that some influencers provide useful tutorials or tips, and this kind of content can be used as a source of inspiration rather than promoting unrealistic standards.

“Those beauty ideals are realistic, because, like influencers, they post some tutorials. They can be used style-wise, and use them for inspiration.” (Betty, Q3)

Theme 3: Comparisons to Others

Comparing oneself to other people was a universal experience shared by all participants, which was caused by the highly curated content they saw on their social media feeds. For Larry, these comparisons have already become a habit, although it was emotionally exhausting and depressing.

“In the last two years, I compared appearance all the time. It’s hard not to because every scroll on social media shows someone who looks effortlessly good.” (Larry, Q5)

This tension and insecurity was echoed by Alex as well.

“There’s often a lingering thought of ‘Why don’t I look like that?’” (Alex, Q6)

On the other hand, Betty reflected more critically on the content she consumed. She found style or makeup videos motivating, but noted that body-type comparisons had a more negative impact on her self-image.

“When seeing videos about style, skin, or makeup, then I see it as ways to improve, but when the videos are about body type, then it affects my self-image, but it doesn’t affect my self-worth.” (Betty, Q6)

Theme 4: Fear of Judgement

Many participants showed an increasing awareness of how they are perceived online, often resulting in anxiety or changing their behavior. For some, this meant editing photos or choosing specific poses before posting in order to minimize self-doubt and conform to the norm.

“I edit every picture before posting — it makes me feel comfortable. If not edited, it makes me anxious.” (Larry, Q8)

“I won’t post things that I feel insecure about... I try to be at an angle where I feel ‘skinny.’” (Betty, Q9)

Meanwhile, Adam reported not editing his photos at all, but he still acknowledged that social media affects everyone to some extent.

“It affects everyone, but I don’t believe it has a major impact on my self-confidence.”

Findings & Interpretation

The in-depth interviews conducted for this study reveal that social media has a complex impact on shaping perceptions of beauty and influencing mental health of the members of Generation Z. A key finding across all interviews is the tendency to compare one’s appearance to others on social media, including influencers, celebrities, and peers. These comparisons usually happen automatically during daily social media use, resulting in negative feelings like anxiety

and insecurity. Participants indicated that repeated exposure to polished and highly curated images lowers their confidence and makes them more self-critical. Moreover, most participants agreed that many of the beauty ideals portrayed online, such as flawless skin, or specific body types, are difficult for most people to achieve. Factors like time, financial resources, and professional resources (e.g. lighting or filming) are seen as necessary to achieve these looks.

Despite this, the relationship between the viewers of beauty content and the content itself is not completely negative. Tutorial videos from influencers, especially about clothing style, skincare, and makeup, are seen as inspiring and useful. These forms of content were viewed as tools for self-improvement and creative expression rather than sources of pressure. At the same time, there are more body-positive and alternative beauty viewpoints spreading online. As a result, these new trends challenge the old, narrow beauty standards. This change shows that online beauty ideals are becoming more diverse. Some users actively look for these broader representations. It is important to note that not all beauty content is perceived as harmful. The effect on an individual's mental health depends on the type of content and how the user approaches it. Gen-Z viewers seem more selective and thoughtful than expected. They can tell the difference between helpful self-improvement content and harmful comparisons. Participants' reflections suggest that, while they remain susceptible to emotional harm, they are also developing media literacy and selective viewing habits, which may help them build resilience to negative messages as they grow older.

Across the interviews, participants also shared strong feelings of self-consciousness about how others see them online. This includes editing photos before posting, choosing specific angles or lighting to appear more slim, or avoiding posting entirely due to fear of judgment. Although the intensity of anxiety varied among individuals, there was a shared understanding

regarding the psychological impact of social media self-presentations. This online presentation does not just affect how others perceive them, but also influences how they see themselves in real life.

This study offers new insights into Gen-Z's relationship with beauty standards on social media. While existing research has primarily focused on the negative effects of appearance-based comparison and unattainable ideals, the present findings suggest a more complicated situation. Participants reported both emotional harm and the emergence of critical awareness, indicating that young users are not merely passive consumers. Instead, they are able to selectively engage with content, accepting or rejecting it based on personal values and perceived relevance.

However, several limitations must be acknowledged. First, the sample size of the study was small ($n = 4$) and demographically narrow, consisting only of college-aged participants from relatively similar urban academic settings. Although efforts were made to include a range of gender identities, including male, female, and LGBTQ+ participants, the group was not representative of the broader Gen-Z population in terms of socioeconomic background, geographic location, or cultural diversity. This limits the generalizability of the findings. Second, all data were derived from self-reported interviews. While participants were encouraged to speak openly, the possibility of memory bias or social desirability bias cannot be ruled out. Certain emotional experiences, particularly those related to insecurity or vulnerability, may have been underreported or selectively disclosed. The interview format, by nature, also relies on participants' willingness to reflect and articulate their thoughts, which may vary in depth and honesty. Third, although the qualitative design of this study offers rich, detailed perspectives, it does not allow for generalizations across the broader population, nor can it determine causal relationships between social media use and mental health outcomes.

For future research, the study should seek to expand the sample to include greater diversity across race, gender identity, geographic region, and media usage patterns. Including a wider range of male, non-binary, and LGBTQ+ voices would be especially valuable in exploring how intersecting identities shape the experience of beauty norms online. Longitudinal studies could also track shifts in perception over time, offering insight into how media literacy or maturing perspectives influence emotional resilience. Additionally, future studies might examine the role of platform algorithms and content moderation in shaping users' exposure to harmful or helpful beauty-related content. Interventions such as digital literacy education or algorithm transparency initiatives may offer protective benefits. Research could also explore alternative sources of resilience, including online communities, humor, or peer support networks that help buffer the negative effects of beauty standards in digital environments.

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Appendix

Participant 1: Larry (21, Male, Asian, IG & TikTok, 4-5 hrs/day)

Q1: How would you describe the types of beauty content you usually see on your feed?

A: Very polished (e.g. toned body, sharp jawline, clear skin)

- Fitness influencers or fashion models

Q2: Are there certain influencers or celebrities whose appearance you see often?

A: Yes -> many pop music artists & k-pop idols, also a Chinese influencer called Harrison Yu

- It feels like the algorithm knows what kind of body types grab my attention

Q3: Do you think these beauty ideals are realistic or achievable for most people? Why or why not?

A: No -> most of them are taken after tons of preparation

- It's impossible for people to live perfectly all the time
- Those preparations need time & money & energy -> difficult for most people because we need to work

Q4: Do you believe that there are specific looks or standards that are promoted on social media? If so, what are they?

A: Yes, and there are specific standards for different people.

- E.g. mine: In gay community -> emphasis on "fit but not bulky," trendy but not too much
- "I really don't like these standards. It's too limited."

Q5: Have you ever compared your appearance to people you see on social media?

A: In last two years -> compared appearance all the time

- It's hard not to because every scroll on social media shows someone looks effortlessly good
- From this year -> feel better, but those contents still exist and popup as usual
 - Mindset changing: Maybe because I begin thinking about whether it's right/wrong to judge others' bodies.. Like staring at other's bodies is impolite too.
 - And it's influenced by social media as well & my friend: They reflect on the topic of beauty standards a lot.

Q6: How do those comparisons usually make you feel (confidence/self-esteem)?

A: most of time it makes me feel so anxious, and feel like "I'm not good enough" -> even not attractive

- But still sometimes I feel motivated
 - Not sure why, maybe because I'm happy during that period -> so no anxiety

Q7: Has social media ever made you feel insecure about your looks or body? Can you describe an example?

A: A music release party last year -> everyone dressed up and looked super pretty super hot

- Before I even got there, I had already seen people posting Stories from the venue, and everyone looked so polished and confident -> made me feel like I had to "keep up" even before walking in although I already spend a lot of time on my fitting, hairstyle and makeup
- After the party, people started uploading pictures and tagging others. When I saw some photos with me in them, I just didn't like the way I looked.
 - Like, my face looked puffier than I thought, or my posture seemed off -> just not chill and perfect as others
 - I ended up not posting anything myself because I felt like I didn't match the 'vibe' that everyone else had.
- I feel so weird -> it was actually a fun night, but social media kind of ruined the memory.
 - It turned into this self-comparison spiral, where I couldn't stop thinking about how I looked instead of what I actually experienced.

Q8: Do you feel pressure to change anything about your appearance because of what you see online?

A: thinking about changing hairstyle and whitening teeth

a. Do you feel pressured to filter or edit your photos before you share/post them?

- A: I edit every picture before post them -> it makes me feel comfortable
 - If not edited -> it makes me anxious

Q9: Do you believe social media in general has made you more self-conscious about how you are perceived by others? (liking, commenting, views)

A: I don't care about the liking/comments/views

- But I pay more attention to myself, like what angle I look best in, kind of judging myself based on the beauty standards

Participant 2: Betty (19, Female, White and Vietnamese, IG & TikTok, 1 hrs/day

Q1: How would you describe the types of beauty content you usually see on your feed?

A: makeup videos / tutorials / fit checks / skincare / dieting / workout stuff

Q2: Are there certain influencers or celebrities whose appearance you see often?

A: molly faye, mondet mcmichael, eden masliah

Q3: Do you think these beauty ideals are realistic or achievable for most people? Why or why not?

A: Yes, because they give you tutorials or tips / Yes, for style-wise wise because you can use them for inspiration

Q4: Do you believe that there are specific looks or standards that are promoted on social media? If so, what are they?

A: Yes, it depends on what type of social media you see because everyone's feed is different —> hers is healthy ways to improve life, but not unhealthy habits like on skinny tok

Q5: Have you ever compared your appearance to people you see on social media?

A: Yes

Q6: How do those comparisons usually make you feel (confidence/self-esteem)?

A: When seeing videos about style/skin/makeup, then she sees it as ways to improve but when its videos about body type, then it affects her self-image, but it doesn't affect her self-worth

Q7: Has social media ever made you feel insecure about your looks or body? Can you describe an example?

A: 13 very young and impressionable looked online, saw how everyone was so well developed, and felt insecure —> looked at a lot of fitness influencers

Q8: Do you feel pressure to change anything about your appearance because of what you see online?

A: No pressure, but if she likes what she sees, she will try to make a change

Q9: Do you feel pressured to filter or edit your photos before you share/post them?

A: No but she won't post things that she feels insecure in like she will try to be at an angle where she feels "skinny"

Q10: Do you believe social media in general has made you more self-conscious about how you are perceived by others? (liking, commenting, views)

A: Yes because she feels constantly judged online

Participant 3: Alex (19, Female, White, IG & Snapchat, 4-5 hrs/day)

Q1: How would you describe the types of beauty content you usually see on your feed?

A: More body positivity recently

- A lot of parenting/postpartum moms also (reality of what our bodies go through)
- In the past → more stereotypical (algorithms funnels what we see)
- There is some shift in standards that are pushing back on the norm and creating change

Q2: Are there certain influencers or celebrities whose appearance you see often?

A: No, not really,

- My algorithm isn't geared towards that type of content
- But there is a Norway couple that defies beauty standards (more muscular and bigger body)

Q3: Do you think these beauty ideals are realistic or achievable for most people? Why or why not?

A: No, it's very unrealistic

- Models often wear pre-fitted clothes → clothes don't fit the way they appear (prepared beforehand, unnatural)
- Many people on social media aren't transparent about how "real" their appearances are

Q4: Do you believe that there are specific looks or standards that are promoted on social media? If so, what are they?

A: Yes, the norm pushed onto women is a lot about being thin, fragile, and pretty

- However, people are trying to push back on it, showing more realistic side to beauty

Q5: Have you ever compared your appearance to people you see on social media?

A: Yes, it's very hard not to compare yourself to others

- More specifically people who are close to my age, or people who do things that I wish I did, such as being more active

Q6: How do those comparisons usually make you feel (confidence/self-esteem)?

A: There's often a lingering thought of "Why don't I look like that?"

- Many beauty standards being unhealthy and unrealistic is a fact
- I don't feel this as strongly, but the intensity of this differs for people who live different lifestyles

Q7: Has social media ever made you feel insecure about your looks or body? Can you describe an example?

A: Yes, when I first got social media (Instagram) when I was younger, before covid

- Could see how happy others looked on social media and compared myself to them
 - Seeing people who look happy on the beaches in Florida when I'm at home alone
 - Social media exposes you to a larger community
 - Thought this way, but things that you see aren't always true
- Social media doesn't show the full story, you can often misinterpret it and it hurts your self-esteem

Q8: Do you feel pressure to change anything about your appearance because of what you see online?

A: Yes, wish I was more in shape but not really pressured to change anything, I like my body the way it is

- I think it's less about changing and more about making us feel strongly about different norms, which leads to insecurities and hurts self-esteem
 - Seeing people and comparing yourself makes you feel worse about yourself
 - If someone is talking about counting calories in a video (something more measurable), that might be different and might cause an actual change in someone's behavior
- Do you feel pressured to filter or edit your photos before you share/post them?
 - Yes, but only blending my face or getting rid of acne

Q9: Do you believe social media in general has made you more self-conscious about how you are perceived by others? (liking, commenting, views)

A: Yes, it can go two ways

- The number of likes encourages comparing between you and others and your own posts
→ opens the door to the norm about how people think of you in everyday life
- We have trained ourselves to react to appearances and to see standards in a specific way, making us assume what others think of us
- People are very judgy in general, which is hard to navigate

Participant 4: Adam (21, Male, White, IG and Tiktok, 2-3 hours a day)

1. How would you describe the types of beauty content you usually see on your feed?
 - Mostly fashion influencers and gym influencers
2. Are there certain influencers or celebrities whose appearance you see often?
 - Most of his feed are popular gym influencers
 - Jeff Nippard
 - fashion influencers, every so often
3. Do you think these beauty ideals are realistic or achievable for most people? Why or why not?
 - Doesn't think the beauty ideals are realistic or achievable
 - Influencers have more resources that aren't accessible
 - Years of training, most people don't have the time or give effort to reach the beauty standards
4. Do you believe that there are specific looks or standards that are promoted on social media? If so, what are they?
 - There is a specific type of look
 - Tall, lean and muscular

Personal Impact

1. Have you ever compared your appearance to people you see on social media?
 - Yes → most people have compared themselves to everything seen on social media
2. How do those comparisons usually make you feel (confidence/self-esteem)?
 - Hurts confidence

- Body isn't at the same level as influencers even though he workouts often
 - Learned to be more comfortable
3. Has social media ever made you feel insecure about your looks or body? Can you describe an example?
- Yes → despite working out often seeing all the “perfect” bodies online
 - Shouldn't compare because they've been working out for longer, some use PED's
 - Appreciates their hard work, but hard not to compare
4. Do you feel pressure to change anything about your appearance because of what you see online?
- No → Wants to be where he is comfortable and not where he would have the “perfect” body
 - a. Do you feel pressured to filter or edit your photos before you share/post them?
 - No, never edited a picture
5. Do you believe social media in general has made you more self-conscious about how you are perceived by others? (liking, commenting, views)
- Yes → affects everyone, but doesn't believe it had a major impact on self confidence